

CASE ID: 199704710390

EPISODE NAME: China–Denmark UN Human Rights Resolution Dispute

1997/04/08 - 2000/05/11

Sender: China (710)

Target: Denmark (390)

Issue: Contain Political Influence (1)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after sanctions imposition (9)

Summary:

On 1997/04/08, China threatened Denmark with diplomatic and economic sanctions in retaliation for Denmark's introduction of a UN resolution condemning China's human rights record. China successfully marshaled the votes to kill the Danish resolution, and imposed diplomatic sanctions, on 1997/04/15. Tensions eased when Danish prime minister Poul Nyrup Rasmussen traveled to China on an official state visit on 2000/05/11.

Narrative:

On 1997/04/08, China threatened Denmark with diplomatic and economic sanctions in retaliation for Denmark's introduction of a UN resolution condemning China's human rights record.¹ Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Shen Guofang issued the vague threat of sanctions, telling reporters that if Denmark proceeded with its proposal, "relations will be severely damaged in the political and economic trade areas."²

On 1997/04/15, China successfully marshaled the votes to kill the Danish resolution,³ which was strongly backed by the United States, but not backed by France, Germany, Italy, or Spain due to these countries' fear of damaging trade relations with China.⁴ The resolution criticised China's repression of freedom of expression, and called upon the country to release political prisoners and reform its judicial system.⁵ The UN Commission on Human Rights voted "no action" on the bill 27 to 17.⁶ Also on 1997/04/15, China imposed diplomatic sanctions in announcing a

¹ Chu, Henry and Craig Turner. "China Blocks Rights Measure, Punishes Denmark for Effort." *Los Angeles Times*, April 16th, 1997, www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1997-04-16-mn-49192-story.html.

² Lewis, Paul. "China Warns Denmark On Resolution." *The New York Times*, April 8th, 1997. <https://www.nytimes.com/1997/04/08/world/china-warns-denmark-on-resolution.html>.

³ Chu, Henry, and Turner, Craig. "China Blocks Rights Measure, Punishes Denmark for Effort." *Los Angeles Times*, April 16th, 1997. www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1997-04-16-mn-49192-story.html.

⁴ King, Toby. "Human rights in European foreign policy: success or failure for post-modern diplomacy?." *European Journal of International Law*, Volume 10, Issue 2, 1999, pp. 313–337. <https://doi.org/10.1093/ejil/10.2.313>.

⁵ Chu, Henry, and Turner, Craig. "China Blocks Rights Measure, Punishes Denmark for Effort." *Los Angeles Times*, April 16th, 1997. www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1997-04-16-mn-49192-story.html.

⁶ "Commission on Human Rights Votes for Special Rapporteur on Nigeria; Resolution on China Fails to Come to a Vote | Meetings Coverage and Press Releases." *United Nations*, April 16th, 1997. press.un.org/en/1997/19970416.hrcn804.html.

suspension of bilateral state visits with Denmark, including over the “human rights issue.”⁷ There were no economic sanctions imposed by China on Denmark.

Relations appear to have gradually recovered, and the episode ended when Danish prime minister Poul Nyrup Rasmussen traveled to China on an official state visit on 2000/05/11.⁸

⁷ “China cancels exchanges with Denmark.” *UPI*, April 15th, 1997.
<https://www.upi.com/Archives/1997/04/15/China-cancels-exchanges-with-Denmark/6677861076800/#:~:text=April%2015%2C%201997,human%20rights%20dialogue%20with%20China>.

⁸ “Reception Held to Celebrate Sino-Danish Ties.” *People’s Daily*, 11 May 2000,
en.people.cn/english/200005/11/eng20000511_40645.html.